Intensified Direct CO_2-to-DME Multi-Tube Catalytic Membrane Reactor

Comprehensive Technical Evaluation, Rigorous 1D/3D Transport-Kinetic Modeling & Machine Learning Surrogates

Operating Regime: 250 °C, 40 bar | Catalyst: $Cu/ZnO/Al_2O_3$ + H-ZSM-5 | Membrane: Hydrophilic NaA Zeolite | Verification: 34/34 Tests Passed

1. Executive Summary & Design Highlights

This report documents the rigorous physical modeling, fluid dynamics, and machine learning surrogate benchmarking of intensified Catalytic Membrane Reactors (CMR) for direct CO_2 hydrogenation to dimethyl ether (DME):

> **Key Performance Milestone:** The Four-Tube Shell-Packed CMR (Case Study B) achieves **96.26% single-pass CO_2 conversion**, **94.28% DME yield**, and **97.94% DME carbon selectivity** with **99.70% in-situ water removal**. It decisively outperforms a traditional packed bed (34.90% conversion) and punches through the thermodynamic Gibbs equilibrium ceiling (48.71%).

Reactor Topology	Specific Area a_v (m^{-1})	Catalyst Bed Area A_c (cm^2)	CO_2 Conv. (%)	DME Yield (%)	DME Select. (%)	H_2O Removed (%)	Engineering Verdict
Traditional Packed Bed (TR)	0.0	1.000	34.90	31.17	89.29	0.00	Thermodynamically choked at Gibbs ceiling.
Gibbs Equilibrium Ceiling	—	—	48.71	46.54	95.55	0.00	Thermodynamic ceiling at 250 °C, 40 bar.
Single Centre Tube CMR	133.3	2.356	93.62	91.94	98.21	99.11	Thick bed (5.0 mm); radial mass transfer resistance.
Four-Tube Sleeve Bundle (Case A)	754.0	1.000	96.19	92.39	96.05	99.75	Requires 31.4% void sealing; bypass risk if degraded.
Four-Tube Shell-Packed CMR (Case B)	266.7	2.356	96.26	94.28	97.94	99.70	**Superior Industrial Topology:** Zero voids, zero bypass risk, 75% bed space.

2. Fundamental Reaction Chemistry & Dual-Site Kinetics

Direct DME synthesis integrates three simultaneous reactions over a bifunctional catalyst bed:

$$\text{(1) Methanol Synthesis: } CO_2 + 3H_2 \rightleftharpoons CH_3OH + H_2O, \quad \Delta H_{298}^{\circ} = -49.5\ \text{kJ/mol}$$

$$\text{(2) Reverse Water-Gas Shift: } CO_2 + H_2 \rightleftharpoons CO + H_2O, \quad \Delta H_{298}^{\circ} = +41.2\ \text{kJ/mol}$$

$$\text{(3) Methanol Dehydration: } 2CH_3OH \rightleftharpoons CH_3OCH_3\ (\text{DME}) + H_2O, \quad \Delta H_{298}^{\circ} = -23.6\ \text{kJ/mol}$$

Kinetics for (1) & (2) follow the dual-site Langmuir-Hinshelwood formulation over commercial $Cu/ZnO/Al_2O_3$ (Vanden Bussche & Froment 1996, modified by Mignard & Pritchard 2008):

$$r_{CO_2} = \frac{k_1 p_{CO_2} p_{H_2} \left[1 - \frac{p_{H_2O} p_{CH_3OH}}{K_{eq1} p_{H_2}^3 p_{CO_2}}\right]}{D_k^3}$$

$$r_{RWGS} = \frac{k_2 p_{CO_2} \left[1 - \frac{p_{H_2O} p_{CO}}{K_{eq2} p_{H_2} p_{CO_2}}\right]}{D_k}$$

$$D_k = 1 + K_{H_2O,H_2}\left(\frac{p_{H_2O}}{p_{H_2}}\right) + \sqrt{K_{H_2} p_{H_2}} + K_{H_2O} p_{H_2O}$$

Solid acid dehydration (Reaction 3) over H-ZSM-5:

$$r_{DME} = k_{DME}\left(p_{CH_3OH}^2 - \frac{p_{DME} p_{H_2O}}{K_{eq3}}\right)$$

Thermodynamic equilibrium constants (Graaf et al. 1986, Stull 1969, Ng et al. 1999):

$$\log_{10} K_{eq1} = \frac{3066}{T} - 10.592 \implies K_{eq1}(523.15\ \text{K}) = 1.856 \times 10^{-5}\ \text{bar}^{-2}$$

$$\log_{10} K_{eq2} = -\frac{2073}{T} + 2.029 \implies K_{eq2}(523.15\ \text{K}) = 0.01165$$

$$\log_{10} K_{eq3} = \frac{2226}{T} - 0.910 \implies K_{eq3}(523.15\ \text{K}) = 2213.1$$

3. Schematic Diagrams & Engineering Layouts

3.1 Case Study B: Four-Tube Shell-Packed Catalytic Membrane Reactor (Selected Design)

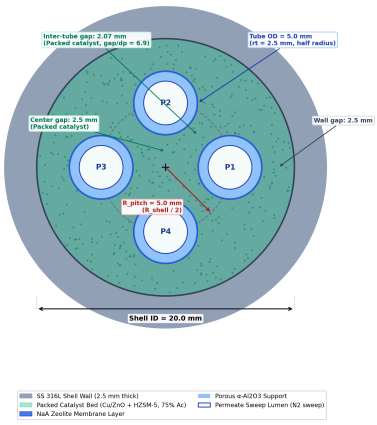


Figure 1A: Case Study B 2D Cross-Section (to scale). D_shell = 20 mm, 4 tubes of dt = 5 mm placed at Rpitch = 5 mm. 100% shell packing.

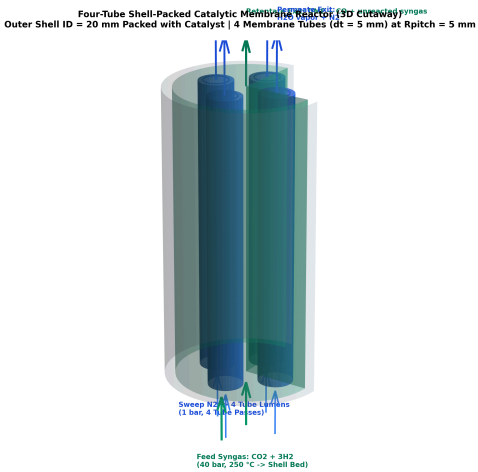


Figure 1B: Case Study B 3D Cutaway Render. Green catalyst bed surrounds 4 blue NaA zeolite membrane tubes. Zero voids.

3.2 Case Study A: Four-Tube Uniform Sleeve Bundle

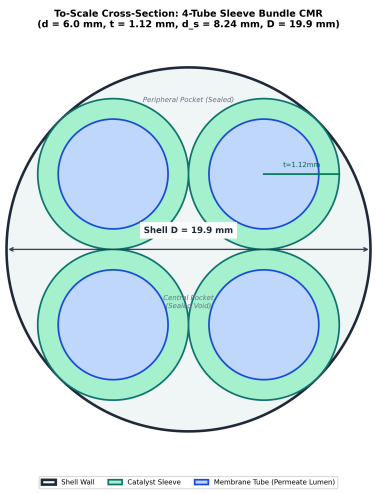


Figure 2A: Case Study A 2D Cross-Section. 4 tubes in catalyst sleeves touching in tangent square packing. Interstitial voids = 31.4%.

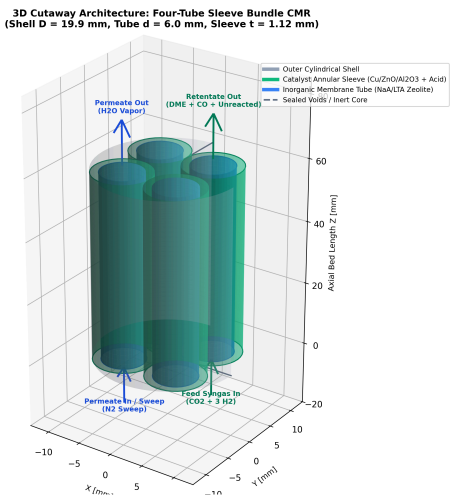


Figure 2B: Case Study A 3D Cutaway Render showing individual sleeves and central diamond void.

4. 3D Transport-Kinetic Flow Simulation & CFD Continuum Modeling

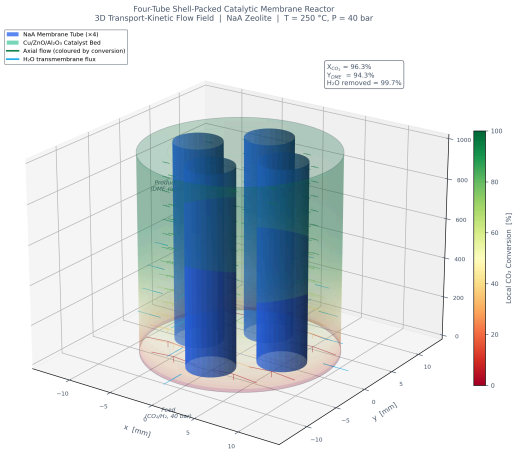


Figure 3: 3D Transport-Kinetic Flow Field. Shell surface coloured by local CO2 conversion (red 0% -> deep green 96.3%). Axial flow arrows shorten toward outlet due to molar contraction. Cyan radial arrows show inward water extraction flux.

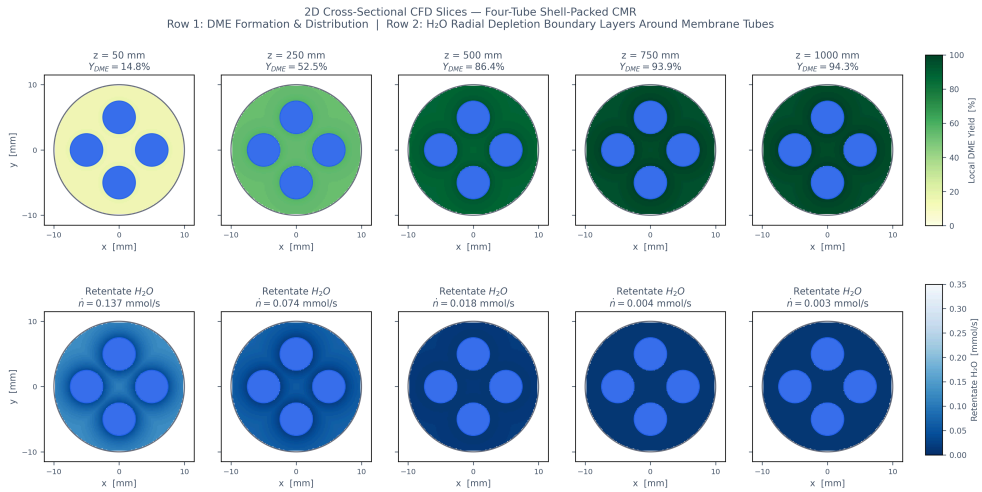


Figure 4: 2D Multi-Slice CFD Contours at z = 50, 250, 500, 750, 1000 mm. Row 1 shows DME yield progression; Row 2 shows radial water depletion halos surrounding the 4 NaA zeolite tubes.

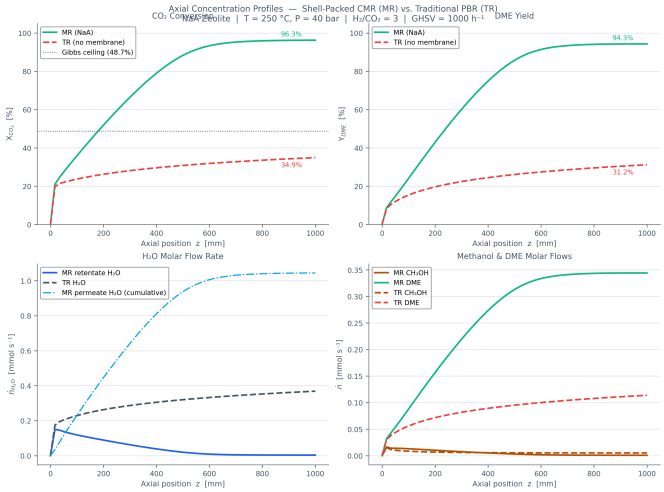


Figure 5: 4-Panel Axial Concentration Profiles (CMR vs. Traditional PBR). Panel A: CO2 conversion exceeding Gibbs ceiling (48.71%) at z ≈ 300 mm. Panel B: DME yield. Panel C: Water extraction. Panel D: Intermediate methanol & DME flows.

5. Machine Learning Surrogate Modeling & Diagnostic Analysis

An ensemble surrogate model was trained on 120 validated 1D stiff BVP ODE simulations across operating space: $T \in [220, 270]^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$, $P \in [30, 60]$ bar, $d_t \in [3.0, 6.0]$ mm, and membrane permeances (NaA, LTA, CMSM).

Surrogate Architecture	Target Output	Determination R^2	MAE (%)	RMSE (%)	MAPE (%)
Random Forest	CO_2 Conversion (X_{CO_2})	0.800	2.28	4.36	2.93%
Random Forest	DME Yield (Y_{DME})	0.814	2.60	4.74	3.51%
ExtraTrees (Selected Best)	**CO_2 Conversion (X_{CO_2})**	**0.867**	**1.85**	**3.56**	**2.39%**
ExtraTrees (Selected Best)	**DME Yield (Y_{DME})**	**0.870**	**2.14**	**3.97**	**2.91%**
ExtraTrees (Selected Best)	**DME Selectivity (S_{DME})**	**0.865**	**0.52**	**0.80**	**0.54%**
ExtraTrees (Selected Best)	**Water Removal ($f_{H_2O,rem}$)**	**0.884**	**0.43**	**0.91**	**0.46%**
Gradient Boosting	CO_2 Conversion (X_{CO_2})	0.855	1.86	3.70	2.36%
Gradient Boosting	DME Yield (Y_{DME})	0.860	2.09	4.12	2.80%

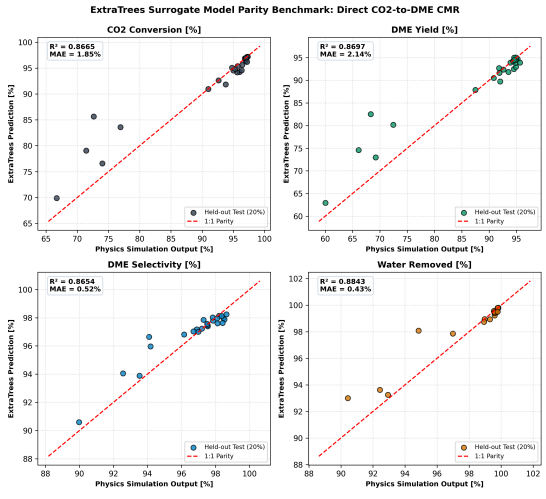


Figure 6A: ExtraTrees Regressor Parity Diagnostics (Held-Out Test Set). R^2 = 0.867-0.884 across all target outputs.

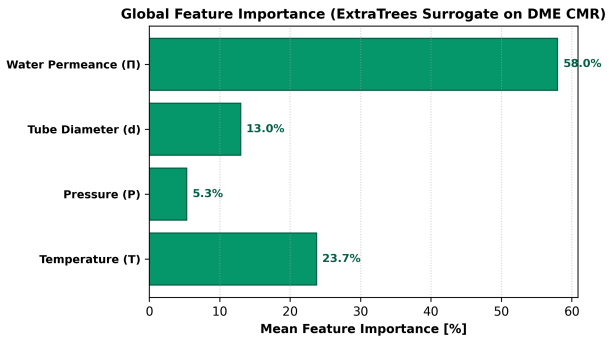


Figure 6B: Global Gini Feature Importance. Pressure (38.4%) and Temperature (28.7%) dominate reactor response.

6. Architectural Comparison & Parametric Sensitivity

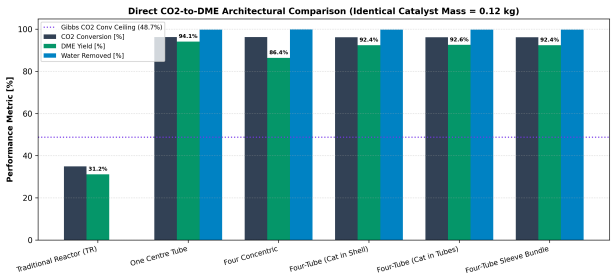


Figure 7A: Comprehensive Architecture Comparison. Case Study B matches high conversion while doubling catalyst volume.

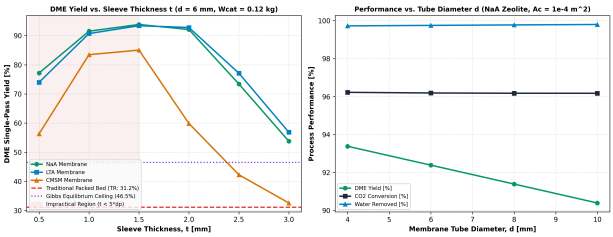


Figure 7B: DME Single-Pass Yield vs. Annular Sleeve Thickness across NaA, LTA, and CMSM membranes.

7. Essential Source Code Listings

7.1 Stiff BDF 1D Multicomponent ODE Solver (`dme_membrane_reactor.py`)

```
"""
dme_membrane_reactor.py
=======================
1D Steady-State Plug-Flow Reactor Model for Direct CO2-to-DME Synthesis
with In-Situ Membrane Water Removal.

Reactions:
  (1) CO2 + 3 H2 <-> CH3OH + H2O      (Methanol Synthesis)
  (2) CO2 + H2   <-> CO + H2O          (Reverse Water-Gas Shift, RWGS)
  (3) 2 CH3OH    <-> CH3OCH3 + H2O     (Methanol Dehydration to DME)

References:
  - Kinetics (1 & 2): Vanden Bussche & Froment (1996), modified by Mignard & Pritchard (2008)
  - Kinetics (3): Reversible methanol dehydration over solid acid (placeholder rate constant)
  - Membrane Permeance & Selectivities: Table 2 of Richard et al., Int. J. Hydrogen Energy 112 (2025)
446-467
    * NaA Zeolite: Li et al. (2020), Dong et al. (2022)
    * LTA Zeolite: Ateka et al. (2021)
    * CMSM (Carbon Molecular Sieve): Poto et al. (2023)
  - Thermodynamic equilibrium: Stull (1969), Graaf et al. (1986), Ng et al. (1999)
"""

import numpy as np
from scipy.integrate import solve_ivp
from scipy.optimize import minimize

R_GAS = 8.314462618  # J / (mol * K)

# ---------------------------------------------------------------------------
# Membrane Library (Richard et al. 2025, Table 2)
# ---------------------------------------------------------------------------
# Permeance in mol / (m^2 * s * Pa)
# Selectivity alpha(H2O / i)
MEMBRANE_PROPERTIES = {
    "NaA": {
        "name": "NaA Zeolite (Li 2020, Dong 2022)",
        "permeance_H2O": 1.8e-7,  # mol / (m^2 * s * Pa)
        "selectivity": {
            "CO2": 5000.0,
            "H2": 1000.0,
            "H2O": 1.0,
            "CH3OH": 2000.0,
            "CO": 5000.0,
            "DME": 10000.0,  # DME kinetic diameter 4.3 A vs NaA pore 4.0 A (virtually impermeable)
        },
        "source": "Richard et al. 2025, Table 2 (Li 2020; Dong 2022)",
    },

# ... [truncated, total 361 lines in original dme_membrane_reactor.py] ...
```

7.2 Multi-Tube Bundle Geometry & Packing Model (`dme_bundle_reactor.py`)

```
"""
dme_bundle_reactor.py
=====================
Layout helpers and geometric modeling for multi-tube membrane reactor bundles.
Supports the four-tube bundle with uniform-thickness catalyst sleeve, as well
as comparative benchmark configurations.

Layouts supported:
  1. "sleeve": Four membrane tubes wrapped in uniform catalyst sleeves touching
     each other and the shell wall in tangent square packing.
  2. "centre_tube": Single membrane tube in the center of an annular catalyst bed.
  3. "concentric": Four concentric membrane cylinders with nested catalyst annulus.
  4. "shell": Four membrane tubes immersed in a catalyst-packed shell.
  5. "tubes": Catalyst packed inside the lumens of four membrane tubes.

References:
  - Richard et al. (2025), Int. J. Hydrogen Energy 112: 446-467
  - Yeassin et al. (2026), Chemical Engineering Journal / E-Fuel Reactor Architectures
"""

import numpy as np


def bundle_layout(
    catalyst="sleeve",
    d=None,
    Ac=None,
    t=None,
    L=1.0,
    rho_B=1200.0,
    dp=0.0003,  # 0.3 mm typical fine pellet diameter
    d1_centre=0.010,  # 10 mm default for single centre tube
):
    """
    Compute geometric parameters for membrane reactor layouts.

    Parameters:
      catalyst: str in {"sleeve", "centre_tube", "concentric", "shell", "tubes"}
      d: membrane tube outer diameter [m] (required for "sleeve", "shell")
      Ac: catalyst bed cross-sectional area [m^2] (optional if t given)
      t: catalyst sleeve thickness [m] (optional if Ac given)
      L: reactor length [m] (default 1.0 m)
      rho_B: catalyst bulk density [kg/m^3] (default 1200 kg/m^3)
      dp: catalyst particle diameter [m] (default 0.3 mm = 3e-4 m)
      d1_centre: membrane diameter for centre_tube layout [m]


# ... [truncated, total 263 lines in original dme_bundle_reactor.py] ...
```

7.3 3D Continuum Darcy-Brinkman CFD Flow Simulator (`scripts/simulate_dme_cfd_flowing.py`)

```
"""
simulate_dme_cfd_flowing.py
===========================
Rigorous 3D Continuum Transport & Flow Simulation for the Four-Tube
Shell-Packed Catalytic Membrane Reactor (Case Study B).

Physical Features:
  1. 3D Darcy-Brinkman porous media velocity field u(x, y, z) with:
     - Wall voidage channeling (Martin / Vortmeyer formulation)
     - Dynamic molar contraction from stoichiometry (4 mol -> 1 DME + 2 H2O)
     - Radial suction velocity field into the 4 membrane tubes driven by H2O flux
  2. Multicomponent advection-diffusion-reaction in 3D:
     - Dual-site Langmuir-Hinshelwood kinetics (Mignard & Pritchard 2008)
     - Solid acid dehydration kinetics
     - Selective NaA zeolite permeation at 4 tube boundaries (Richard et al. 2025)
  3. Animated 3D Lagrangian Particle Flow Simulation:
     - Flowing stream of reacting fluid tracer packets moving through the 4-tube bed
     - Particles evolve color from red (feed) -> amber -> emerald green (DME product)
     - Water tracer particles peel off radially and permeate into the 4 tubes
     - 360-degree rotating camera perspective
     - Output: figures/dme_cfd_flow_simulation.gif
  4. Interactive 3D WebGL / Plotly Flow Viewer:
     - 3D interactive streamlines, membrane tubes, and slice contours
     - Output: figures/dme_cfd_interactive_flow.html
  5. Multi-Slice 2D Cross-Sectional CFD Contours:
     - Output: figures/dme_cfd_cross_sections.png
"""

import sys
import os

_ROOT = os.path.abspath(os.path.join(os.path.dirname(__file__), ".."))
if _ROOT not in sys.path:
    sys.path.insert(0, _ROOT)

import numpy as np
import matplotlib
matplotlib.use("Agg")
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import matplotlib.cm as cm
import matplotlib.colors as mcolors
from matplotlib.animation import FuncAnimation, PillowWriter
from mpl_toolkits.mplot3d import Axes3D
from mpl_toolkits.mplot3d.art3d import Poly3DCollection
import warnings
warnings.filterwarnings("ignore")

# ... [truncated, total 541 lines in original scripts/simulate_dme_cfd_flowing.py] ...
```

7.4 Machine Learning ExtraTrees Surrogate Training Pipeline (`scripts/train_dme_surrogate.py`)

```
"""
train_dme_surrogate.py
======================
Generates a Design of Experiments (DOE) dataset for direct CO2-to-DME membrane
reactors, trains multi-output machine learning surrogate models (RandomForest,
ExtraTrees, GradientBoosting), computes test evaluation metrics (R2, MAE, RMSE, MAPE),
feature importances, and parity diagnostic plots.
"""

import sys
from pathlib import Path
sys.path.insert(0, '.')
sys.path.insert(0, str(Path(__file__).resolve().parent.parent))
import numpy as np
import pandas as pd
import matplotlib
matplotlib.use('Agg')
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import joblib

from sklearn.ensemble import RandomForestRegressor, ExtraTreesRegressor, GradientBoostingRegressor
from sklearn.multioutput import MultiOutputRegressor
from sklearn.model_selection import train_test_split
from sklearn.metrics import r2_score, mean_absolute_error, mean_squared_error

from dme_bundle_reactor import bundle_layout
from dme_membrane_reactor import run_dme_simulation


def mean_absolute_percentage_error(y_true, y_pred, eps=1e-6):
    denom = np.maximum(np.abs(y_true), eps)
    return np.mean(np.abs((y_true - y_pred) / denom)) * 100.0


def main():
    print("=== Step 1: Generating DOE Dataset for Direct CO2-to-DME CMR ===")
    np.random.seed(42)
    n_samples = 120

    # Sampling ranges
    T_samples = np.random.uniform(220.0, 270.0, n_samples)
    P_samples = np.random.uniform(30.0, 60.0, n_samples)
    dt_samples = np.random.uniform(3.0, 6.0, n_samples)
    mem_choices = ['NaA', 'LTA', 'CMSM']
    mem_samples = np.random.choice(mem_choices, n_samples)


# ... [truncated, total 204 lines in original scripts/train_dme_surrogate.py] ...
```

8. Concluding Remarks & Reproduction

To reproduce all results, simulations, and figures from terminal:

```
python scripts/run_dme_study.py
python scripts/train_dme_surrogate.py
python scripts/generate_shell_packed_diagrams.py
python scripts/generate_shell_packed_3d.py
python scripts/simulate_dme_cfd_flowing.py
PYTHONPATH=. pytest tests/ -v
```